

Republic of the Philippines  
**HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES**  
Quezon City

**TWENTIETH CONGRESS**  
First Regular Session

**HOUSE BILL NO. 1699**



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Introduced by **HON. MIGUEL LUIS R. VILLAFUERTE**

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**EXPLANATORY NOTE**

In 2023, top government executives confirmed that the Philippines ranks 1st in digital illiteracy and 2nd in online sexual exploitation of children in the world.<sup>1</sup> A 2021 data from the Philippine Institute for Development Studies further shows that around 40% of the population only have at least one of the six information and communications technology skills monitored for the Sustainable Development Goals. Compared to our ASEAN counterparts, the country lags in almost all ICT skills.<sup>2</sup> To address this alarming situation, the government must strengthen its regulatory capacity and institutionalize proactive measures to help our people, especially the youth, keep up with the knowledge and skills needed today in our highly digitalized context.

As defined by ASEAN, digital literacy is the person's ability to use digital platforms for finding, consuming, evaluating, creating, and communicating digital content.<sup>3</sup> With an average of 8 hours and 52 minutes of internet usage daily, ranking third highest in the world,<sup>4</sup> the government must ensure that the time spent online by our *kababayans* are maximized for learning, business, and capacity-building, contributing to nation-building. Hence, a need to ensure increased digital literacy and improved digital skills in our population.

As our education system plays a vital role in instilling knowledge and discipline, especially in young people, it needs to be updated periodically to adapt to the changing landscape of our society. In line with this objective, this bill seeks to:

- Integrate into the education curriculum of students in Grades 6 to 12 basic concepts of coding, digital literacy, responsible AI use, and algorithmic thinking, among others.
- Revise the curriculum in tertiary education to include at least one AI-related subject across non-tech courses.
- Mandate the Commission on Higher Education to establish a ladderized "Digital Career Track" in State Universities and Colleges.
- Mandate the Technical Education and Skills Development Authority to establish Regional Future Skills Centers that will (1) offer free training programs in digital coding,

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<sup>1</sup> Abarca, C. (2023, September 19). *PH is no. 1 in digital illiteracy, no. 2 in online child abuse* – execs. Inquirer.net.

<https://newsinfo.inquirer.net/1833725/ph-is-no-1-in-digital-illiteracy-no-2-in-online-child-abuse-execs>

<sup>2</sup> Philippine Institute for Development Studies. (2021, December 17). *Fact Friday on digital literacy skills of Filipinos*.

<https://www.pids.gov.ph/details/fact-friday-on-digital-literacy-skills-of-filipinos>

<sup>3</sup> UNICEF East Asia and Pacific. (2020). *Digital literacy in education systems across ASEAN*.

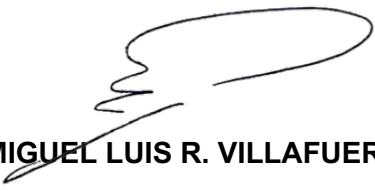
[https://www.unicef.org/eap/media/7766/file/Digital%20Literacy%20in%20Education%20Systems%20Across%20ASEAN%20Cover.p](https://www.unicef.org/eap/media/7766/file/Digital%20Literacy%20in%20Education%20Systems%20Across%20ASEAN%20Cover.pdf)

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<sup>4</sup> Meltwater. (2025). *Social Media Statistics in the Philippines*. <https://www.meltwater.com/en/blog/social-media-statistics-philippines>

- digital marketing, data science, cloud computing, and AI tools, and (2) government-subsidized certification programs on global tech platforms.
- Create a Youth Digital Work and AI Talent Acceleration Fund, which will be used to provide scholarships and subsidies to young people from low-income families and support AI events.
  - Incentivize local government units to conduct youth digital work programs.
  - Create a National Council on AI and Digital Talent that will be headed by the Secretary of the Department of Information and Communications Technology.

To further equip our youth to be future-ready, the swift passage of this measure is earnestly sought.



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**AN ACT INSTITUTIONALIZING DIGITAL LITERACY, CODING, AND AI READINESS IN  
BASIC AND HIGHER EDUCATION, ESTABLISHING REGIONAL FUTURE SKILLS  
CENTERS, AND PROMOTING LIFELONG DIGITAL UPSKILLING FOR ALL FILIPINOS, AND  
APPROPRIATING FUNDS THEREFOR**

*Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives of the Philippines in Congress assembled:*

**SECTION 1. *Short Title.*** – This Act shall be known as the “National Digital Skills and AI Readiness Act.”

**SECTION 2. *Declaration of Policy.*** – It is the policy of the State to prepare every Filipino for the rapidly evolving digital and AI-driven global economy. The State recognizes the need to equip the youth and workforce with future-proof skills such as digital literacy, coding, data analytics, and artificial intelligence to ensure inclusive development, employment generation, and technological competitiveness.

**SECTION 3. *Objectives.*** – The program shall have the following objectives:

- (a) Integrate digital skills and AI education across all levels of formal education;
- (b) Establish Regional Future Skills Centers to provide free training and certifications;
- (c) Facilitate public-private partnerships in upskilling programs;
- (d) Promote digital inclusion for marginalized sectors; and
- (e) Foster ethical awareness and critical thinking in the use of AI technologies.

**SECTION 4. *Digital Curriculum Reform in Basic Education.*** – Immediately upon the effectivity of this Act, the Department of Education (DepEd), shall revise the existing educational curricula to achieve the following:

- (a) Integrate basic coding, digital literacy, and algorithmic thinking in the Grades 6 to 12 curriculum;
- (b) Provide modules on responsible AI use, digital safety, and ethics;

- (c) Ensure teachers receive upskilling and certification in digital teaching methods; and
- (d) Collaborate with local IT companies for curriculum development and real-world relevance.

**SECTION 5. *Digital Curriculum Reform in Higher Education*** – The Commission on Higher Education (CHED) shall revise the existing educational curricula in tertiary education by requiring all SUCs to offer at least one AI-related subject across non-tech courses including, but not limited to Business, Education, and Agriculture as may be determined by the CHED.

Furthermore, CHED shall establish a ladderized “Digital Career Track” across fields within SUCs, from certificate to degree programs to ensure the augmentation of this Act.

**SECTION 6. *Establishment of Regional Future Skills Centers***. – The Technical Education and Skills Development Authority (TESDA), in collaboration with the Department of Information and Communications Technology (DICT) and the Commission on Higher Education (CHED), shall establish at least one (1) Future Skills Center in every region to offer free training programs in digital coding, digital marketing, data science, cloud computing, and AI tools, as well as government-subsidized certification programs on global tech platforms including, but not limited to Google, Microsoft, OpenAI, and Amazon Web Services (AWS).

The Future Skills Center shall offer on-site and online learning options accessible to all interested students, Overseas Filipino Workers, Senior Citizens, and Out-of-School Youth to further improve their skills or simply acquire new skills or knowledge for whatever purpose it may deem serve them.

**SECTION 7. *Creation of the Youth Digital Work and AI Talent Acceleration Fund***. – An acceleration fund on Youth Digital Work and AI Talent shall be created to provide training scholarships and laptop subsidies for low-income youth and support AI bootcamps, hackathons, and incubators across the country.

**SECTION 8. *Role and Incentives for LGUs***. – Local government units (LGUs) that launch youth digital work programs within their respective jurisdictions, with the guidance of the implementing agencies mentioned herein, shall be given incentives, which shall be determined upon the effectivity of this Act.

**SECTION 9. *Creation of the National Council on AI and Digital Talent***. – A National Council on AI and Digital Talent shall be created to be headed by the Secretary of DICT or its duly designated representative, and composed of a representative of DepEd, CHED, TESDA, Department of Trade and Industry, Department of Labor and Employment (DOLE), and industry leaders. The council shall administer the following:

- (a) Publication of an annual AI and Tech Jobs Forecast Report;
- (b) Development of the National AI Literacy Framework; and
- (c) Ensuring inclusive access to digital upskilling across rural and urban.

**SECTION 10. *Appropriations***. – Such amount as may be necessary to implement the provisions of this Act is hereby included in the annual appropriations of DICT, DepEd, CHED, and TESDA under the General Appropriations Act (GAA).

**SECTION 11. *Implementing Rules and Regulations.*** – The DICT, in coordination with relevant agencies, shall issue the necessary Implementing Rules and Regulations within ninety (90) days after the effectivity of this Act.

**SECTION 12. *Separability Clause.*** – If any provision or part of this Act is declared unconstitutional, the remaining parts or provisions not affected shall remain in full force and effect.

**SECTION 13. *Repealing Clause.*** – All laws, executive orders, issuances, and rules and regulations inconsistent with this Act are hereby repealed or modified accordingly.

**SECTION 14. *Effectivity.*** – This Act shall take effect fifteen (15) days after its publication in the Official Gazette or in a newspaper of general circulation.